The objectives

- ✓ To define gender identity and differentiate between the transgendered and transsexuals individuals
- ✓ To describe forms of sexism that exists in the society
- ✓ To differentiate between, Gender equality, equity and inequality
- ✓ To demonstrate knowledge of gender analysis, awareness and sensitivity
- ✓ To describe how homophobia occurs in the society
- ✓ To understand gender mainstreaming and empowerment.

Gender Identity

Gender identity is the extent to which one identifies as being either masculine or feminine (Diamond 2002). It refers to the degree to which an individual sees herself or himself as feminine or masculine.

Gender identity is an individual's self-conception of being male or female based on his or her association with masculine or feminine gender roles.

Some people are born with ambiguous sex characteristics and may be assigned one sex at birth but develop a different identity related to gender.
Some cultures allow people to move freely between genders regardless of their biological sex

NB: Gender identity is not a stable, fixed trait – rather it is socially constructed and may vary overtime for an individual

Individuals who identify with the role that is the opposite of their biological sex are called **transgendered**. Transgendered males, for example, have such a strong emotional and psychological connection to the feminine aspects of society that they identify their gender as female. The parallel connection to masculinity exists for transgendered females.

Transgendered individuals who wish to alter their bodies through medical interventions such as surgery and hormonal therapy—so that their physical being is better aligned with gender identity—are called **transsexuals**. They may also be known as male-to-female (MTF) or female-to-male (FTM) transsexuals.

Not all transgendered individuals choose to alter their bodies: many will maintain their original anatomy but may present themselves to society as the opposite gender. This is typically done by adopting the dress, hairstyle, mannerisms, or other characteristic typically assigned to the opposite gender. It is important to note that people who cross-dress, or wear clothing that is traditionally assigned to opposite gender, are not necessarily transgendered. Cross-dressing is typically a form

of self-expression, entertainment, or personal style, not necessarily an expression against one's assigned gender (APA 2008).

Stereotypes

Stereotypes are oversimplified/overgeneralizing notions about members of a group.

Gender stereotyping involves over generalizing about the attitudes, traits, or behavior patterns of women or men. For example, women may be thought of as too timid or weak to ride a motorcycle. Gender stereotypes form the basis of sexism

Sexism

Sexism refers to prejudiced/biased beliefs that value one sex over another or the prejudiced beliefs that value males over females.

Common forms of sexism in modern society include gender-role expectations, such as expecting women to be the caretakers of the household. Sexism also includes people's expectations of how members of a gender group should behave. For example, women are expected to be friendly, passive, and nurturing; when a woman behaves in an unfriendly or assertive manner, she may be disliked or perceived as aggressive because she has violated a gender role (Rudman, 1998). In contrast, a man behaving in a similarly unfriendly or assertive way might be perceived as strong or even gain respect in some circumstances.

Sexism varies in its level of severity. In parts of the world where women are strongly undervalued, young girls may not be given the same access to nutrition, health care, and education as boys. Further, they will grow up believing that they deserve to be treated differently from boys.

M Sexism can exist on a societal level such as in hiring, employment opportunities, and education. In the United States, women are less likely to be hired or promoted in male-dominated professions such as engineering, aviation, and construction (Blau, Ferber, & Winkler, 2010; Ceci & Williams, 2011).

Gender Socialization

Gender socialization is the process of learning the social expectations and attitudes associated with one's sex.

Gender Equality

Gender equality is achieved when women and men enjoy the same rights and opportunities across all sectors of society, including economic participation and decision-making, and when the different behaviours, aspirations and needs of women and men are equally valued and favoured.

Gender equality is measured by looking at the representation of men and of women in a range of roles

"Gender equality requires equal enjoyment by women and men of socially-valued goods, opportunities, resources and rewards."

In other words, gender equality refers to equal access to social goods, services and resources and equal opportunities in all spheres of life for both men and women.

When there is gender inequality, it is women that are more likely to be disadvantaged and marginalized; but we should not ignore the negative impact that gender inequality can have on men as well.

For example, societal norms regarding the appropriate behaviour for men tend to put them under pressure as regards the need to provide materially for their family, and also deny them opportunities of being more nurturing towards their children and wife.

Therefore gender equality is the concern of all and changes must be brought about for both men and women. However, this is not to say that men and women are equally affected by gender inequality. It remains true that women have the greater share of disadvantages.

However, gender equality, as defined above, does not often result in equal outcomes for men and women. Being given the same chances in life is not sufficient to bring about true equality. Women and men have different needs and experiences and accommodation should be made for these differences. For example, giving boys and girls equal access to all the courses offered in a school may not result in girls taking advantage of this opportunity if some courses are predominantly filled with male students and have only male teachers. There is still the unfortunate tendency to consider male norms as a measure for women's position.

Providing women and men with the same opportunities is the first step; but for true gender equality to be achieved there is a need for gender equity.

Gender Equity

Gender equity is the process of being fair to women and men." (UNFPA)

Women and men should not only be given equal access to resources and equal opportunities, but they should also be given the means of benefiting from this equality. This is where the concept of ‘gender equity' comes into play.

Gender equity implies fairness in the way women and men are treated. The different life experiences and needs of men and women are taken into consideration and compensation is made for women's historical and social disadvantages. The lower status of women in society often constitutes a handicap and provisions should be made to redress this inequality before they can

take advantage of the opportunities provided. Gender equity thus serves to level the playing field and empower women. Therefore, we can say that equity is essential to achieve true equality.

Gender Inequality

Gender inequality can be defined as allowing people different opportunities due to perceived differences based solely on issues of gender. Gender discrimination is the prejudicial treatment of an individual or group due to gender. Gender inequality and discrimination are generally discussed as pertaining to women, but anyone can experience gender-based inequality or discrimination.

Gender Analysis

Gender analysis

Examines the differences in women's and men's lives, including those which lead to social and economic inequity for women, and applies this understanding to policy development and service delivery. It is concerned with the underlying causes of these inequities. It aims to achieve positive change for women

Gender analysis recognizes that:

- ✓ women's and men's lives and therefore experiences, needs, issues and priorities are different
- ✓ women's lives are not all the same; the interests that women have in common may be determined as much by their social position or their ethnic identity as by the fact they are women
- ✓ women's life experiences, needs, issues and priorities are different for different ethnic groups
- ✓ the life experiences, needs, issues, and priorities vary for different groups of women (dependent on age, ethnicity, disability, income levels, employment status, marital status, sexual orientation and whether they have dependants)
- ✓ different strategies may be necessary to achieve equitable outcomes for women and men and different groups of women

Gender analysis aims to achieve **equity**, rather than equality.

Gender analysis provides a basis for robust analysis of the differences between women's and men's lives, and this removes the possibility of analysis being based on incorrect assumptions and stereotypes.

Gender Awareness

Gender awareness is an understanding that there are socially determined differences between women & men based on learned behavior, which affect their ability to access and control resources. This awareness needs to be applied through gender analysis into programmes, policies and evaluation.

Gender awareness is the ability to view society from the perspective of gender roles and how this has affected women's needs in comparison to the needs of men.

Gender Sensitivity

Gender sensitivity is translating this awareness into action in the design of development policies, programs and budgets.

Gender sensitivity is the act of being sensitive to the ways people think about gender. Gender sensitivity tries to ensure that people rely less on assumptions about traditional and outdated views on the roles of men and women.

Gender Discrimination

Gender discrimination is also known as gender bias.

It is a situation in which someone is treated less well because of their sex, usually when a woman is treated less well than a man:

Gender discrimination means differential treatment based on a person's gender or sex, which more often affects girls and women. Because of gender discrimination, girls and women do not have the same opportunities as boys and men for education, meaningful careers, political influence, and economic advancement.

Gender discrimination usually results in women experiencing social inequality but it also occurs when people are targeted because they do not conform to gender norms related to their biological sex.

Homophobia

Homophobia is a range of negative attitudes and feelings towards lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgendered and **intersex** people which denies their humanity, dignity and personhood.

For instance, a society is **homophobic** when it is structured so that heterosexuality is socially and institutionally reinforced.

Gender Mainstreaming

Gender mainstreaming involves bringing the contribution, perspectives and priorities of both women and men to the centre of attention in the development arena in order to inform the design, implementation and outcomes of policies and programs. It is a critical strategy not only in the pursuit of gender equality – a development goal in its own right – but also in the achievement of

other development goals, including economic ones. Indeed, overlooking relevant gender factors in macroeconomic policies and institutions can undermine the successful outcome of those very same policies and institutions".

Mainstreaming Gender Perspective

Mainstreaming gender perspective is the process of assessing the implications for women and men of any planned action, including legislation, policies or programs, in all areas and at all levels. It is a strategy for making women's as well as men's concerns and experiences an integral dimension of the design, implementation, monitoring and evaluation of policies and programs in all political, economic and societal spheres so that women and men benefit equally and inequality is not perpetuated. The ultimate goal is to achieve gender equality.

Empowerment

Empowerment refers to increasing the spiritual, political, social or economic strength of individuals and communities. It often involves the empowered developing confidence in their own capacities.

Empowerment is probably the totality of the following or similar capabilities:

1.Having decision-making power of their own
2.Having access to information and resources for taking proper decision
3.Having a range of options from which you can make choices (not just yes/no, either/or.)

4.Ability to exercise assertiveness in collective decision making
5.Having positive thinking on the ability to make change
6.Ability to learn skills for improving one's personal or group power.
7. Ability to change others' perceptions by democratic means.
8. Involving in the growth process and changes that is never ending and self-initiated
9. Increasing one's positive self-image and overcoming stigma

Summary

From the subtopics above, we have defined Gender identity; stereotypes; Sexism; Gender socialization; Gender equality; gender equity; gender inequality; Gender analysis; Gender awareness; Gender sensitivity; Gender discrimination; Homophobia; Gender mainstreaming; mainstreaming gender perspective and empowerment.